DBQ Sourcing 5D: Purpose

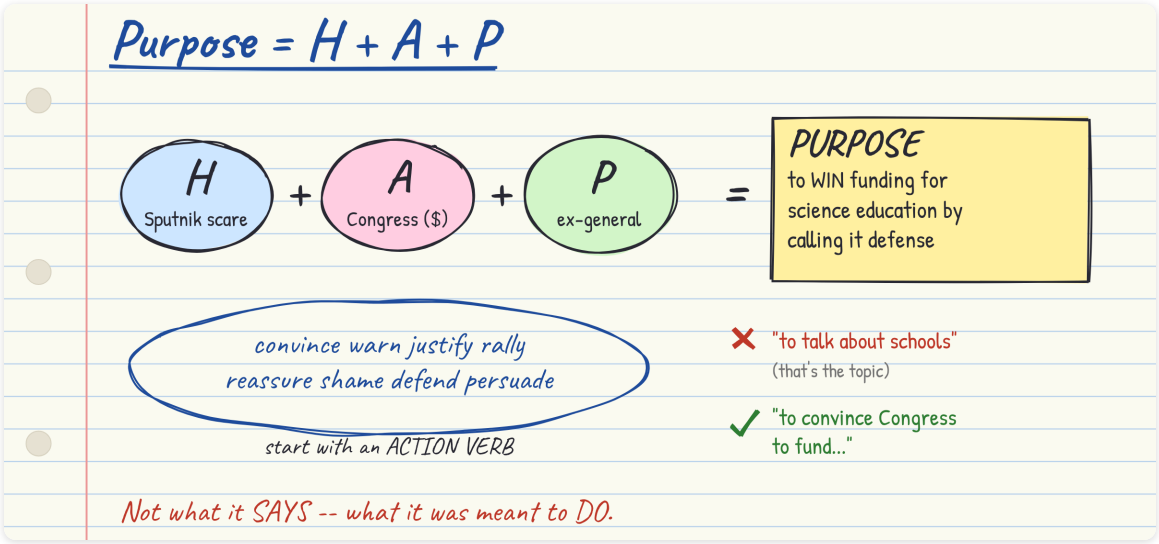
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What purpose means

Purpose is *why* the document was created — what the author wanted the audience to believe or do — and it is usually the product of the other three HIPP elements:

- **Historical situation** creates the need (a crisis, a law, an election).
- **Intended audience** tells you who must be moved (Congress, voters, consumers).
- **Point of view** tells you what the author wants out of it (their role, beliefs, stake).

Put those together and the purpose is often obvious. That's why the strongest sourcing sentences in the samples chain them: "As a [POV], writing to [audience] during [situation], [author] sought to…" See the diagram in DBQ Point Guide 5: Sourcing Overview (HIPP).



To earn credit, a purpose explanation must:

1. **State the goal with an action verb**: convince, warn, justify, rally, shame, reassure, persuade.
2. **Be grounded in the document**, not guessed: the author's goal should be visible in what they say.
3. **Connect it to the argument**: what the goal reveals about the prompt.

The common failure is a purpose sentence that stops at the goal ("to show slavery was bad") without saying why that matters for the essay's argument.

The formula

Build purpose from the other three, then connect:

> "[During situation], [author], as a [point of view], [wrote / spoke] to [audience] in order to [action verb] them to [belief / action]. This shows [argument]."

1. **Jot H, A, and P in the margin** for the document (one or two words each).
2. **Ask: given all three, what did the author want?** Write it with an action verb.
3. **Check it against the text.** Point to the line where the author asks for something, warns, or argues.
4. **Write the chain sentence.** You don't have to use all three; one is enough to ground the purpose.
5. **Finish with "This shows…"** tied to the thesis. This sentence earns the credit.

Purpose verbs that work: convince, persuade, justify, warn, reassure, rally, mobilize, shame, criticize, defend, recruit, request funding for.

Cold War DBQ purposes, built from H + A + P (written for this guide):

Doc	H + A + P	Purpose
A	McCarthy era + press and public + Republican president	To calm public "hysteria" and distance the administration from reckless investigators
B	Guatemala coup + Americans and Latin American states + hard-line Secretary of State	To justify U.S. intervention as defense of the whole hemisphere
E	Arms race + Americans and the Soviets + new Democratic president	To show resolve to Moscow while inviting arms talks
G	Post-Sputnik + Congress + former general	To win emergency federal education funding by calling it national security

Examples that earned credit

Source	Document	What was credited
2025 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 5)	Doc 4 (Kennedy)	Purpose “to convince lawmakers to support the creation of federal healthcare for the elderly,” tied to the argument that changing views about helping citizens expanded government's economic role. Audience (lawmakers) + purpose (convince) in one sentence.
2024 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	Doc 1 (Cushing)	Purpose explained through the hypocrisy between the ideal of “basic legal rights” and state laws allowing slavery.

College Board model sentences:

> "In Document 4, President John F. Kennedy's purpose was to promote the idea that the United States had a moral obligation to intervene and help citizens through actions like government programs to provide health insurance to older Americans." (2025 Set 1)
>
> "Kelley's purpose was to promote purchasing union-made goods so that consumers helped to ensure that factories with good working conditions prospered while those with poor conditions failed." (2025 Set 2)
>
> "Garrison's purpose of shaming northerners for their connections to slavery showed that the North benefited from slavery and not just the South." (2024 Set 1)

The Garrison sentence is the cleanest model: purpose ("shaming northerners") plus what it shows ("the North benefited from slavery").

Cold War model using the full chain (written for this guide):

> "Writing to Congress just months after Sputnik, Eisenhower, a former general, framed education as defense in Document G in order to win emergency federal money for science and engineering. His purpose shows that the government addressed Cold War fear by turning it into support for long-term investment, which was more effective than simply telling Americans not to worry."

Examples that did not earn credit

Source	Attempt	Why it fails
2023 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 4)	Doc 6: Americans "bragged" about factory life	Attempts a purpose but "does not explain how the purpose is relevant to an argument."
2024 guidelines (non-example)	"The point of the drawing in Document 7 is to show Americans that slavery was bad."	Identifies a goal and stops. No "this shows…"
2024 Set 2, Sample 1C (score 3)	Doc 5 purpose	Didn't support an argument, which kept the essay from reaching four sourced documents for complexity.

Cold War non-examples (written for this guide):

- "The purpose of Document E is to give an inaugural address." That's the format, not a goal.
- "Dulles's purpose was to talk about Guatemala." Topic, not purpose; no action verb.
- "Eisenhower's purpose in Document G was to get money for schools." Correct, but it stops. Add *why* (Sputnik, national security) and what it shows about the prompt.

Expert tips

A one-line definition worth memorizing: purpose is **"what a document was intended to do — not what it says, but what it did."** For a nationalist speech by a colonized nation's leader, say what the speech was meant to accomplish, e.g. getting people to rise up and demand independence.

That line is the fastest fix for the most common purpose error: restating content ("the purpose is to talk about Guatemala") instead of naming an intended effect ("to justify intervention").

Grader checklist

1. Does it state a goal with an action verb (not the topic or the format)?
2. Is the goal accurate and visible in the document?
3. Is it grounded in at least one of situation, audience, or point of view? (Not required for credit, but the strongest examples do this.)
4. Is it tied to an argument about the prompt?

Yeses on 1, 2, and 4 = this document counts toward the two needed.

Feedback stem: "You identified the purpose of Document [X]. Make it stronger by explaining what caused it (the situation, the audience, or who the author was), then end with 'This shows…' tied to your thesis."